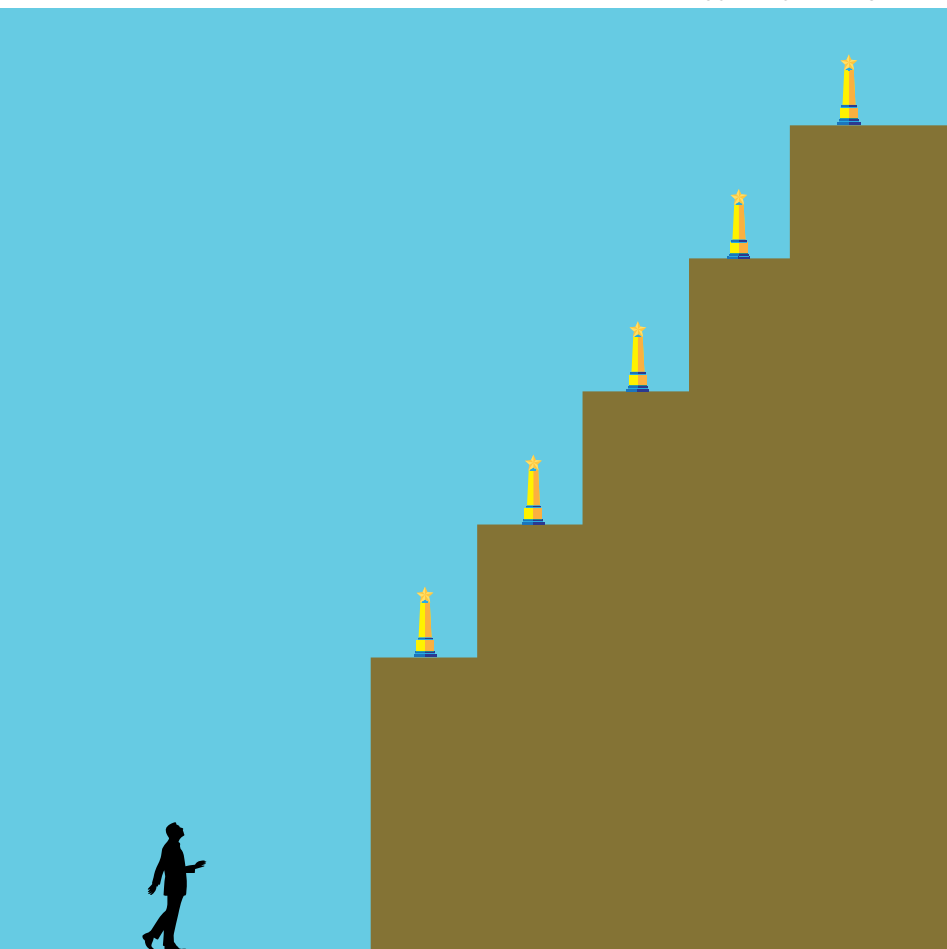


ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA



before buying them, it has become imperative for businesses to reach the customer at the pre-purchase stage, even before the choice to buy a particular product is made.

USING GEN AI

Gen AI is helping maximise productivity and efficiency across industries, serving as a co-pilot or intelligent assistant to the human workforce. Indian CEOs acknowledge the transformative potential of Gen AI and anticipate that it will deliver significant benefits. Around 71% of Indian CEOs expected Gen AI to increase employee efficiency over the next 12 months, while 70% believed it would improve their own

performance. However, these findings underscore the societal responsibility that CEOs have for ensuring their organisations use AI responsibly. For one, companies need to be certain that the data sets used to train large language models (LLMs) are inclusive and diverse. Stringent tests need to be conducted on Gen AI systems to verify their reliability, safety and relevance before deployment. More importantly, there is a need to establish robust internal governance procedures and provide human oversight.

DECARBONISATION

At the COP28 summit in 2023, leaders yet again underscored

the need to transition away from fossil fuels. Rapid decarbonisation of the energy system is a necessity, and 130 countries at the summit pledged to triple the world's installed renewable energy generation capacity. Half of the business leaders polled in our survey believed that regulatory complexities were holding back decarbonisation efforts. Simplifying regulatory processes can accelerate climate action by the private sector. Also, with major Indian firms committing to net-zero targets, it is imperative for businesses in a climate-conscious world to meet investor and customer expectations on sustainability.

CYBERSECURITY

With businesses increasingly embracing digital transformation, the risk of cyberattacks has grown. It is, therefore, not surprising that cybersecurity figures high among Indian CEOs' concerns around factors impacting the growth of their businesses. Cybersecurity fears have become more acute with the advent of emerging technologies, like Gen AI. A majority of Indian CEOs believe Gen AI would increase cybersecurity risk and, therefore, it's important for businesses to put the necessary checks and balances in place.

The increased pressure Indian business leaders expect over the next few years is a sign that continuous reinvention will be needed. Staying ahead then will require every business leader to challenge conventional wisdom, embrace change and leverage potential opportunities, although this will look different for different industries. **BT**

The author is Partner and Leader-Markets, PwC India. Views are personal